

FOR SALE BY OWNER GUIDE

Selling Your Home on Your Own, Step by Step

A plain guide to pricing, showing, and closing in South Carolina.

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A word before you start

You've decided to sell your home yourself. That's your call, and I respect it. Plenty of owners do it well.

This guide is meant to help you do it well. It covers the steps in order, and it's honest about the parts that usually trip people up. Keep it handy.

PART 1

Pricing It Right on Your Own

Start with real sold prices

The price that matters is what similar homes nearby actually sold for. Not what they're listed for, and not what a website guesses.

Where to look

- **Your county's property records.** Greenville and Spartanburg counties both have free online property searches. They show what a home sold for and when.
- **The big home-search sites.** Zillow, Realtor.com, and Redfin show recent sales. Look for homes marked "sold," not "for sale."
- **Ask me.** I'm glad to send you a list of recent sales near you. No cost, no strings.

What makes a good comparison

- Close by, ideally the same neighborhood.
- Sold in the last three to six months.
- Similar size, age, bedrooms, bathrooms, and lot.



Why online estimates miss

Website estimates come from a computer. It has never been inside your home. It doesn't know about your new roof, or that the house next door needed everything. Use the estimate as a starting point, not your price.

Why starting high costs you

- **Buyers look hardest in the first few weeks.** If the price is too high then, the best buyers pass you by.
- **The appraisal.** Most buyers get a loan, and the bank won't lend more than its appraiser says the home is worth. A high price can win a buyer and still lose the sale.
- **Price cuts raise questions.** When a home sits and the price drops, buyers wonder what's wrong with it.

A home priced right from the start usually sells faster, and often for more.

What selling on your own still costs you

- The closing attorney's fee.
- The South Carolina deed recording fee, usually paid by the seller: $3.70 per $1,000 of the price, about $1,110 on a $300,000 home.
- Any buyer's agent fee you agree to.
- A flat-fee MLS service, if you use one.
- The sign, flyers, and any repairs.

PART 2

Getting Buyers in the Door

Where buyers actually look

Most buyers start online, and most work with an agent. Their agent searches the MLS, the listing system local agents use. From the MLS, homes are sent to Zillow, Realtor.com, and hundreds of other sites.

Your options

- **Post it yourself.** Zillow lets owners post a home for free. Your home shows in Zillow's search results, marked "For sale by owner." Owner-posted homes don't go into the MLS, though, so many buyers' agents won't see them.
- **A flat-fee MLS listing.** Some companies will put your home in the MLS for a one-time fee. Read the terms closely, so you know what's included.
- **Facebook and word of mouth.** Tell neighbors, friends, and coworkers. Post on your own page and in local groups.

Photos

Most buyers see your home online first. The photos decide whether they come see it in person.

Tips for better photos

- Shoot on a bright day, with every light on and the blinds open.
- Clear the counters and put away most of the clutter.
- Hold the camera level, at about chest height. Avoid the panorama setting. It bends walls and makes rooms look odd.
- Take the front of the house from across the street, so the whole home fits.
- Use your best 20 to 30 photos, starting with the front.



Showings and safety

Strangers will be walking through your home. A few simple habits keep you and your things safe.

- **Get a name and phone number before every showing.** Call back to confirm it's real.
- **Ask to see a photo ID when they arrive, and snap a picture of it.**
- **Ask if they've talked to a lender.** Serious buyers usually have.
- **Don't show the home alone.** Have a friend or family member there.
- **Put away valuables, medicines, mail, and anything with your personal information.**
- **Walk with the visitors.** Let them look, but stay close.
- **Trust your gut.** If something feels off, it's fine to end the showing.

The yard sign

A sign brings in drive-by buyers and neighbors. Put your phone number in large print. Add a flyer box with a one-page sheet: price, beds, baths, square feet, and a few highlights.

When agents call

Once your sign goes up, agents will call. Some will ask to list your home. You can simply say, "No thanks, I'm selling it myself."

Others will call because they have a buyer. That can be good news. Many buyers work with an agent, and those buyers can be serious.

Decide ahead of time

- **Will you pay a buyer's agent?** The agent may ask you to pay their fee. You don't have to. But if you won't, some buyers may not be able to make an offer. Decide before the calls start, and put any agreement in writing.
- **Who does the paperwork?** The buyer's agent works for the buyer, not for you. You'll still need someone looking out for your side. Your closing attorney can help.

If your home sits

If you've had showings but no offers in 30 days, the price is usually the reason, not the house. Look at what's sold since you listed and adjust.



PART 3

Offers, Paperwork, and Closing in South Carolina

What you must tell buyers by law

South Carolina requires most home sellers to fill out a property condition disclosure statement. You must give it to the buyer **before** you both sign a contract. This applies whether or not you use an agent.

- The form asks what you know about the roof, plumbing, electrical, water, termites, and more.
- Answer what you actually know. You can also mark that you're making no representation about an item.
- If you learn something new before closing that makes an answer wrong, you must give the buyer a corrected form, or fix the problem.
- If your home was built before 1978, federal law also requires a lead-based paint disclosure.

The form is free from the South Carolina Real Estate Commission's website. If I emailed you this guide, the form came with it. If you have a printed copy, text or email me and I'll send it to you.

> An owner who knowingly leaves out or misstates a problem can be held responsible for the buyer's damages. **When in doubt, disclose.**



The contract

In South Carolina, the purchase contract spells out the price, the deadlines, and who pays for what. Use a proper written contract, never a handshake or a homemade page.

Many owners have the closing attorney prepare or review the contract before anyone signs. It's money well spent. A missing date or a vague line can cost you later.

What to look for in an offer

- **Price, and what you walk away with.** Closing costs and any credits the buyer asks for come out of your money.
- **Cash or a loan.** If it's a loan, ask for a letter from the buyer's lender.
- **Earnest money.** The buyer's good-faith deposit. A bigger deposit shows a serious buyer. Agree in writing who holds it. Often it's the closing attorney.
- **The closing date.**

The due diligence period

Most South Carolina contracts give the buyer a due diligence period, often about two weeks. During that time, the buyer inspects the home and can back out for any reason.

The contract can set a fee the buyer pays you if they back out during that period. After the period ends, the buyer can't back out for those reasons.

Repair requests

After the inspection, the buyer may send a list of repairs. You don't have to agree. For each item, you can say yes, say no, or offer something else, like a credit or a lower price.

If you can't agree, the buyer may back out before the due diligence period ends. Most inspection lists are long. Focus on the big items: roof, structure, plumbing, electrical, and heating and cooling.

> **The termite inspection.** Lenders usually require one, and it's done around the same time as the home inspection. If it finds termites or damage, you'll usually be expected to treat and repair it, or work out a credit with the buyer.

The appraisal

If the buyer gets a loan, the bank sends an appraiser to set the home's value. If the appraisal comes in lower than the price, you and the buyer talk it over. You might lower the price, the buyer might pay the difference, or you might meet in the middle. If you can't agree, the buyer may be able to back out, depending on the contract.

This is one more reason pricing it right from the start matters.

The closing attorney

In South Carolina, a licensed attorney must handle the closing. Pick one early. The attorney:

- Checks that the title is clear, meaning nobody else has a claim on your home.
- Pays off your mortgage.
- Prepares the deed and the closing papers.
- Pays you what's left, by check or wire transfer.

> **A word of caution on wire fraud.** Never trust wiring instructions that arrive by email. Call the attorney's office at a number you already know is real.



Your checklist from offer to closing

1

Before any contract

Give the buyer your disclosure statement.

2

Contract signed

Earnest money goes to the agreed holder. Due diligence starts.

3

Weeks 1 and 2

Home and termite inspections. Settle any repair requests.

4

Weeks 2 and 3

The appraisal and the buyer's loan work. The attorney checks the title.

5

Closing day

Sign the papers, hand over the keys, and get paid.

Moving out and closing day

- Be fully moved out before closing.
- The buyer usually walks through the empty home one last time on closing day.
- Bring every key, garage remote, and code to the closing.
- As a courtesy, leave the power and water on for a day or two after closing.





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REALTOR® · NorthGroup Real Estate

Selling on your own takes real work. If it ever gets to be too much, or you just have a question, call me. No pressure.

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Principles Before Profits

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